

THE FOR SALE BY OWNER

MARKETING TOOL KIT



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10 INSIDE TIPS

To Understanding How To Sell Your Own Home

Ask anyone who has sold a home on their own and they'll tell you: from the moment the "For Sale By Owner" sign goes up, the phone starts ringing. Many of those calls won't be from buyers. They'll be from agents hoping to list your home, investors looking for a discount, and people who aren't ready to buy.

Saving on commission is an understandable goal. But selling a home involves pricing, marketing, showings, negotiation, disclosures, and a legal closing process, and each step has its own pitfalls.

The key is being properly prepared. Without preparation, a home can sit on the market longer than expected because it isn't attracting offers from qualified buyers. That's the point where many owners get frustrated and give up. With the right preparation, plenty of owners sell successfully on their own, and you can be one of them.

This guide walks through 10 inside tips to help you sell on your own with confidence, along with what to watch for along the way.

> **THE KEY IS TO BE PROPERLY PREPARED.**

STEP 1

Price It Right

Setting your asking price is critical. Pricing too high can be as costly as pricing too low. The market sets the value of your home, not your emotional attachment to it or what you feel it should be worth.

To set a realistic price, compare the price, features, and condition of similar homes for sale near you, and especially similar homes that have sold in recent months. Online estimates can be a starting point, but they are often off, sometimes by thousands of dollars.

Terms matter as much as price. Know what each potential offer really means for you: the financing type, closing costs you're asked to cover, repair requests, and timing. Budget your selling costs and prepare a net proceeds estimate so you know what you'll actually walk away with. Buyers may ask you for a summary of their costs too.

The 5 Keys to a Successful Sale

PRICE | LOCATION | CONDITION | MARKETING | COMMUNICATION

> **THE MARKET SETS THE PRICE. YOUR JOB IS TO MEET IT.**

STEP 2

Prepare Your Home for Sale

First impressions are everything. Walk through your home with the objective eyes of a buyer and don't gloss over repairs or fix-ups, because buyers won't. Your goal is for your home to stand out from the competition.

Get Packing

- Pack family portraits and personal photos. Neatly displayed landscapes and abstract art are fine.
- Take down decor from crowded walls.
- Move extra furniture into storage so rooms feel open.
- Store worn-out rugs and mats.
- Organize closets and cabinets. If they're overly full, pack half.
- Corral toys and clutter into bins or storage.
- Clear trash from floors and flat surfaces.

Scrub, Scrub, Scrub

- Cabinets and drawers
- Windows, inside and out
- Toilets and showers
- Exterior walkways, decks, and stairs

Finishing Touches

- Hang fresh towels in the bathrooms.
- Replace burned-out light bulbs.
- Do a smell check. Ask a friend if you think you've gone nose blind.
- Right before showings: dishes done, laundry away, trash out.

> **DE-CLUTTER. CLEAN. REARRANGE SO IT'S EASY TO WALK THROUGH EVERY ROOM.**

STEP 3

Prepare the Legal Documents You'll Need

Selling a home involves important legal documents that you must assemble, complete, and understand. Requirements differ by state, so here is a starting checklist for North Carolina and South Carolina sellers.

North Carolina

- Residential Property and Owners' Association Disclosure Statement
- Mineral and Oil and Gas Rights Mandatory Disclosure Statement

South Carolina

- SC Residential Property Condition Disclosure Statement

Both States

- Lead-based paint disclosure (homes built before 1978, federal requirement)
- Purchase contract prepared or reviewed by a real estate attorney

Also Have Ready

- Mortgage payoff statement
- Property survey or plot plan
- HOA documents, dues, and rules, if applicable
- List of personal property included and excluded
- Property fact sheet
- Net proceeds estimate
- Buyer pre-approval letter or proof of funds

In both North Carolina and South Carolina, real estate closings are handled by an attorney. Bring one in early so your contract and disclosures are right from the start.

> **HAVE THE RIGHT LEGAL DOCUMENTS BEFORE YOU ACCEPT AN OFFER.**

Disclosure forms and requirements change. Confirm current forms and your obligations with a real estate attorney.

STEP 4

Market Your Home Effectively

Beyond the sign in your yard, you need to spread the word. Many buyers are already working with an agent, so reach out to active local agents to see if their buyers match your home. Out-of-town buyers matter too, so plan how you'll reach them. Above all, make it easy for prequalified buyers to see your home: answer calls, return messages promptly, and be ready to show quickly.

10 Marketing Exposure Tips

1. **Tell everyone.** Share that your home is for sale on social media and by word of mouth.
2. **Go live.** Post a live video walkthrough a couple of times a week, or as often as you're comfortable. Live video draws more activity than photos alone.
3. **Hire a professional photographer.** Great photos are the first showing.
4. **Tag your network.** Tag friends and coworkers on Facebook, Instagram, LinkedIn, and other platforms. Highlight the home's best features and post weekly updates.
5. **Use Facebook Marketplace.** It's free. Join local buy/sell groups that allow home listings.

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STEP 4

Market Your Home Effectively (continued)

6. **Build a website for your home.** A simple single-property website gives buyers one link with every photo and detail.
7. **Print flyers and postcards.** Call a local print shop, or design your own for free with Canva.
8. **Mail your neighbors.** Send 100 "just listed" postcards to nearby homes using USPS Every Door Direct Mail (EDDM). Neighbors often know someone who wants to move in.
9. **Hold open houses.** Host them yourself or ask a REALTOR® to host one.
10. **Get on the MLS.** Most buyers and their agents search the MLS and the sites it feeds. A flat-fee MLS service can list your home for a set price. Compare current packages, what's included, and recent reviews before you choose.

> **THE MORE QUALIFIED BUYERS WHO SEE YOUR HOME, THE STRONGER YOUR POSITION.**

STEP 5

Remain Objective During Showings

Keep emotion out of the sale. The best way to do that during a showing is to stay in the background. If a buyer says something negative about your home, point out its positives instead of getting defensive.

> **KEEPING EMOTIONS NEUTRAL NETS YOU MORE MONEY.**

STEP 6

Pre-Qualify Your Prospects

Showing your home to buyers who can't afford it wastes your time and wears you out. Before you schedule a showing, ask every buyer for a pre-approval letter from a lender, or proof of funds for a cash purchase.

Ask every buyer for the same thing, and treat every buyer the same. Fair housing laws apply to how you advertise and respond to buyers, even when you sell on your own.

> **SEPARATE THE REAL BUYERS FROM THE WINDOW SHOPPERS.**

STEP 7

Negotiate Effectively and Knowingly

Many details must be resolved before a sale is final: price, terms, inspections, repairs, appraisal, possession date, and buyer concerns. Understand your contract fully so you can explain it to the buyer and make any needed amendments.

Have your contract examined by a real estate attorney. While that's happening, keep the buyer engaged so their interest doesn't fade during negotiations.

> **KNOW EVERY DETAIL OF THE CONTRACT YOU'LL USE.**

STEP 8

Know Your Buyer

Your goal in negotiation is to control the pace. Try to understand the buyer's motivation:

- Do they need to move quickly?
- Is their financing strong enough for your price?
- Are they working with an agent?

Knowing this up front tells you what it will take to get what you want.

> **A BUYER WITH AN EXPERIENCED AGENT NEGOTIATES FROM STRENGTH. BE READY.**

STEP 9

Don't Move Out Before You Sell

Vacant homes often feel cold and forgotten, and they can be harder to sell. Carrying an empty home also costs you money. Moving out early tells buyers you already have a new home and may be motivated to sell fast, which gives them leverage at the negotiating table.

> **AN OCCUPIED, WELL-KEPT HOME USUALLY SHOWS BETTER.**

STEP 10

Know Why You're Selling, and Keep It to Yourself

Understanding yourself is the flip side of understanding your buyer. Your reasons for selling shape everything from your price to how much time and money you'll invest in preparing the home. Decide what matters most: the money you walk away with, how quickly you sell, or both. Different goals call for different strategies.

Whatever your reasons, keep them private so you don't weaken your position. If a buyer asks, simply say your housing needs have changed.

> **KEEP YOUR REASONS FOR SELLING PRIVATE.**

5 BUYER FACTS

Every Owner Selling On Their Own Should Know

1. **First-Time Buyers**
   Many rely on an agent to guide them through financing, offers, contracts, and closing. Expect questions, and expect their agent to be involved.

2. **Relocation Buyers**
   They're often new to the area and short on time, and some are working through a relocation company with its own agent requirements.

3. **Creative-Terms Buyers**
   Some buyers approach owners selling on their own looking for low-down-payment or creative terms, such as rent-to-own. Make sure any offer is backed by real financing before you take your home off the market.

4. **Move-Up Buyers (Often the Best)**
   Many are selling a current home at the same time and are already working with an agent to do it. That agent will often help them find their next home, too.

5. **Bargain Hunters**
   They know you're trying to save on commission, so they may ask for a discount equal to it. If you agree, you could net about the same as if you'd hired an agent, while taking on all the work and risk yourself.

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How to Assess Your Net Gain

To decide whether you'll come out ahead selling on your own, remember that many buyers work with an agent, and how that agent is paid is now negotiated case by case. Be prepared for that conversation. Also be cautious: many buyers, investors, and speculators who seek out owner-sold homes are looking for a bargain, and low offers can leave you with less in the end.

Here's what you'll need to weigh for yourself:

1. **Your preparation.** Are you ready to handle marketing, negotiation, pricing, showings, and every legal requirement?
2. **Your costs.** Add up what it will take to market your home and assemble everything you need, from the yard sign and ads to photography and attorney fees.
3. **Your true net.** What will a buyer likely offer you as an owner selling on your own, minus the costs in point 2? Is that higher than what an experienced agent could likely net you, after the agent's compensation?

> **COMPARE NET PROCEEDS, NOT JUST THE COMMISSION.**

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What to Look Out For

Expect frequent calls from agents hoping to list your home. Some may say they have a buyer and ask to preview the home without one. Investors may call with quick cash offers well below market value. You'll also hear from buyers who aren't qualified, and some will ask about rent-to-own. That's why I always confirm a buyer is qualified before showing them a home. Also keep in mind that your contact information may be publicly visible in your listing.

The True Cost

Online estimates can be wrong. Automated values like Zillow's Zestimate can't see your home's condition or upgrades and may contradict your price, which can cost you thousands of dollars.

Square footage can be misreported. Some spaces, such as basements, are often not counted as finished square footage online. A 3,000 square foot home with half of it in the basement may show up as 1,500 square feet.

Disclosure mistakes are costly. They're one of the most common sources of legal disputes after a sale. Sellers are responsible for disclosing what they know about the property, and many don't realize how much that covers or how to document it properly. An experienced agent helps make sure your disclosures are complete and well documented, which helps protect you. Trying to save on commission can end up costing you more if you aren't properly protected.

Questions? I'm Here to Help.

Want to know what your home is worth in today's market, or just want a second opinion on your plan? Let's talk. No pressure, no obligation.

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